

KEY FIGURES



3.1 million¹

Afghan refugees and others in need of international protection in the sub-region



754,100²

Afghan returns in 2026 from Iran and Pakistan, of which 39% were deported



3.2 million³

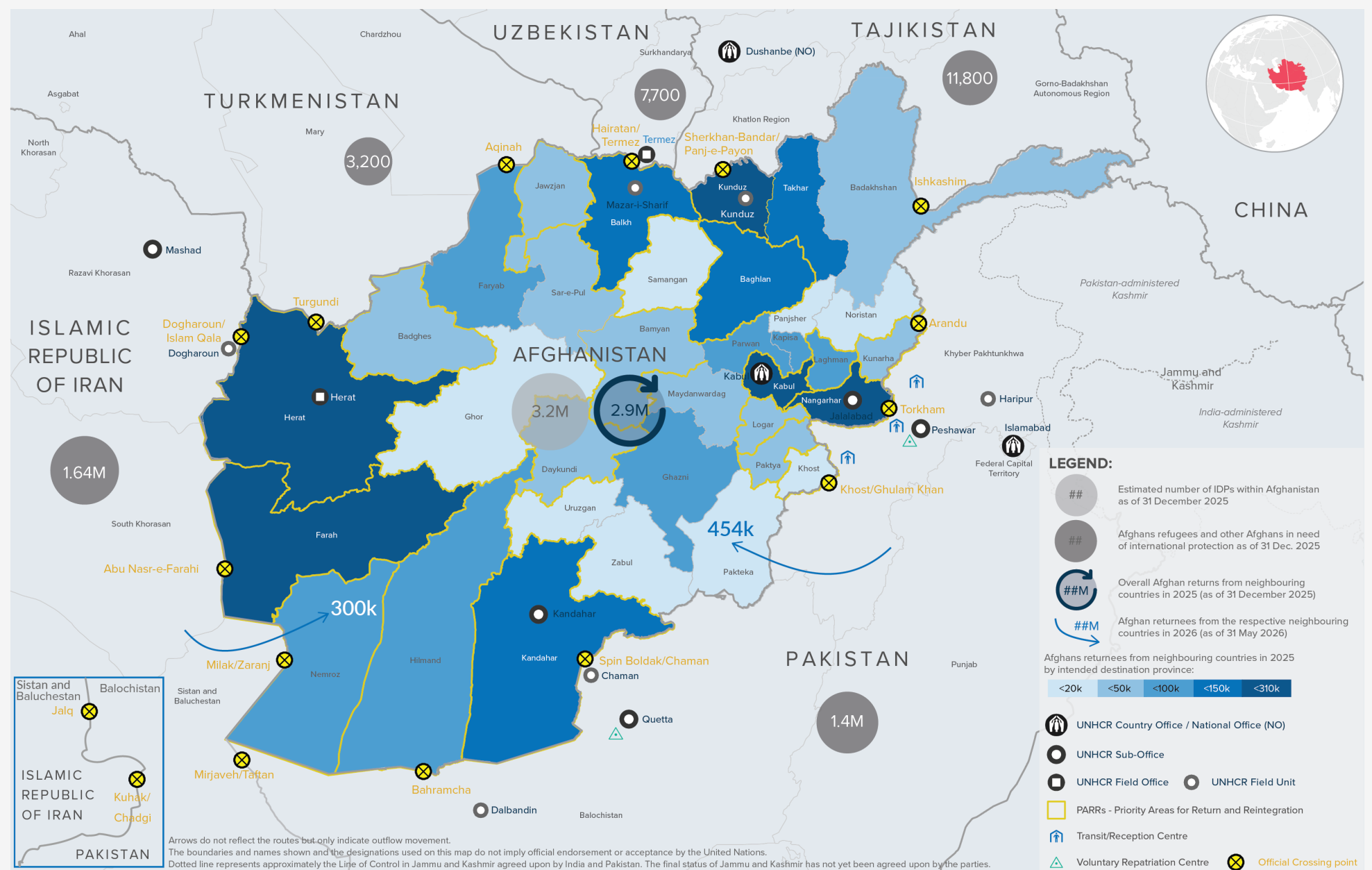
Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs) in Afghanistan and 69k new IDPs in 2026

OPERATIONAL CONTEXT

During May, Afghan returns from Pakistan and Iran to **Afghanistan** continued to strain border reception and assistance capacity, particularly at key crossing points such as Torkham. Cross-border tensions with Pakistan persisted throughout the month, disrupting movement in some eastern border districts. In Herat, de facto authorities announced stricter enforcement of women's dress-code requirements effective from June, further restricting women's participation in public life. While no direct operational impact had been reported by end-May, UN security assessments highlighted potential implications for humanitarian access, community engagement and programmes involving female staff.

Conditions in **Iran** remained challenging throughout May with security incidents contributing to uncertainty and heightened protection risks. UNHCR monitoring indicates that since late February 2026, the protection environment for Afghan refugees has sharply deteriorated due to economic pressures, reduced access to services, documentation challenges, and rising evictions, leading to harmful coping strategies and widespread psychosocial distress. [Protection monitoring](#) published in May highlighted how immediate conflict-related risks have eased since the ceasefire on 8 April, with concerns shifting from crisis needs to persistent economic hardship and legal insecurity. UNHCR maintained its presence in Tehran, Mashhad, Isfahan, Kerman and Dogharoun, enabling continued protection monitoring, documentation and assistance.

In **Pakistan**, arrests and detentions declined in May, largely due to the Eid period and a temporary easing of enforcement, though return movements remained significant. Reports indicate that several deported Afghan men re-entered Pakistan through irregular channels to sustain livelihoods, often living discreetly and relying on informal arrangements to avoid detection. In Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, the environment remained sensitive despite fewer cross-border incidents. In Islamabad and Punjab, enforcement measures, including raids, documentation checks, extortion, and evictions, continued to drive fear, pushing some Afghans into hiding or irregular movement. Sindh remained relatively calm, though post-Eid enforcement in Karachi increased police presence, documentation checks, and detentions, heightening protection risks. In Balochistan the situation remained volatile due to security challenges, with continued arrests despite an overall decrease since April.



¹ As of end-December 2025

² As of 31 May 2026

³ 3.2 million IDPs as of 2025, and 69,000 new IDPs in 2026, as of 3 May from areas reached with assessments.

For the latest figures and updates on UNHCR's broader response in sub-region, visit the [Afghanistan Situation page](#) on UNHCR's Operational Data Portal. For any queries, please contact: RBAPEXT@unhcr.org

Across **Central Asia**, progress and challenges in refugee inclusion and protection persisted during May. In Tajikistan, deportations of Afghan nationals escalated, with 734 individuals deported during the month, amid reports of limited due process or legal assistance. The total number of deportations since January 2026 is now over 1,000 individuals. UNHCR continued cross-border monitoring, assistance, and advocacy with the Government to support affected families and uphold protection standards. Also in Tajikistan, proposed amendments to Government Resolution No. 529 that would exempt refugees and asylum-seekers from work permit requirements advanced in May. Following sustained advocacy by UNHCR and partners, the draft amendments completed inter-ministerial review and are expected to be submitted for Government consideration. If adopted, the changes would improve access to lawful employment, bolster self-reliance and socio-economic inclusion and reduce dependence on humanitarian assistance. UNHCR continues to engage with Government counterparts to support implementation and alignment with international protection standards.

KEY PROTECTION AND SOLUTIONS ISSUES

Protection monitoring in **Afghanistan** continued to indicate that many returns from Pakistan and Iran took place under adverse circumstances, with returnees reporting harassment, arrests, detention, extortion, confiscation of documents and belongings, and mistreatment during return procedures. Women and children accounted for most monitored returnees, alongside reports of unaccompanied and separated children, family separation, and onward movement following arrival. Limited access to shelter, civil documentation, education, livelihoods and basic services impacted sustainable reintegration and increased protection risks, while funding shortfalls reduced support for vulnerable newly arrived households and child protection services.

In **Iran**, worsening economic conditions exacerbated protection risks and socioeconomic vulnerabilities among refugee and host community households. Many refugee households struggled to meet basic needs amid rising costs of housing, food, health care, education and documentation. During May, authorities launched the Amayesh and Movaghat card renewal exercise and clarified eligibility criteria, procedures and fees. While some new administrative requirements were reportedly deferred, concerns remain that documentation and cost-related barriers could limit access to renewal for vulnerable refugees and increase the risk of becoming undocumented.

In **Pakistan**, the continued suspension of registration processes and challenges related to document renewal heightened protection risks, increased anxiety among refugees and asylum-seekers, and restricted access to legal status and basic services. Ongoing implementation of the Illegal Foreign Repatriation Plan (IFRP) drove irregular onward and return movements, with reports of deportees re-entering Pakistan informally to sustain livelihoods, highlighting the need for stronger protection safeguards and durable solutions. Insecurity and access constraints, particularly in border areas, also disrupted humanitarian outreach, underscoring the need for route-based, inter-agency service delivery. In May, UNHCR helpline received 27,497 calls; most enquiries related to case updates, assistance, registration and legal issues.

Across **Central Asia**, efforts to advance refugee inclusion and self-reliance continued alongside persistent protection challenges. In Kazakhstan, refugees gained greater access to information on higher education opportunities through the Government's scholarship programme for foreigners and refugees, supporting education access and implementation of the country's Global Refugee Forum commitments. In Tajikistan, forced returns of Afghans remained a key protection concern despite ongoing advocacy by UNHCR and partners, underscoring the need for continued protection monitoring and efforts to safeguard access to asylum and international protection standards.

UNHCR RESPONSE

In **Afghanistan**, UNHCR maintained border monitoring, protection screening and targeted assistance at key reception points. In May, cash assistance totalling more than USD 1.8 million reached approximately 44,000 people, primarily at Omari Reception Centre and Takhtapul. Protection teams identified and referred people with specific needs, including unaccompanied and separated children, female-headed households and people with disabilities. To help meet immediate needs among new arrivals, hot meal distributions were expanded at key border locations in the south and support was scaled up at Sher Khan Bandar on the Tajikistan border.

In **Iran**, UNHCR continued to provide counselling, legal aid, psychosocial support and financial assistance amid rising humanitarian and protection needs. Demand for the UNHCR Helpline increased, receiving close to 36,000 calls in May, a 4% increase from April, reflecting growing pressures on refugee households. Since the onset of the crisis, UNHCR has assisted nearly 151,000 through helplines, in-person counselling, registration and targeted support. Some 11,000 individuals received in person counselling at UNHCR offices between 1 March – 31 May, out of which almost half (5,500 individuals) were in May. To assess evolving needs and bolster response efforts, UNHCR's Representative in Iran visited Mashhad, Kerman and Shiraz, engaging with authorities, refugee communities and service providers.

In **Pakistan**, UNHCR continued to provide counselling, case management, emergency cash assistance, mental health support, and community outreach. Community feedback indicated deteriorating protection conditions under the IFRP, including displacement, evictions, raids and extortion. Many Afghans are living in hiding, with limited access to services due to documentation issues, gaps in helplines, and barriers to healthcare. Capacity-building with police and stakeholders strengthened refugee protection awareness and referral systems. In Islamabad, the Protection Unit finalised a review by Lahore University of Management Sciences of the Chief Commissionerate for Afghan Refugees concept note, endorsing procedures to address human rights concerns under the IFRP. The proposal will move through government channels to establish protective documentation for vulnerable individuals. In May, the Senior Protection Officer delivered lectures on refugee law and UNHCR's mandate to 281 peacekeepers, students, and civil servants. Progress on statelessness continued, with partner Imkaan supporting ID renewal, applications and awareness activities.

Across **Central Asia**, UNHCR supported efforts to strengthen asylum systems, advance refugee inclusion and prevent statelessness. In Kazakhstan, UNHCR partnered with Maqsut Narikbayev University and the Sanremo International Institute of Humanitarian Law to promote wider adoption of a university course on the protection of refugees and stateless persons, supporting the implementation of Global Refugee Forum commitments. The course has been translated into Kazakh, Kyrgyz and Russian for wider use across the region. UNHCR contributed to consultations on the 2026–2030 National Action Plan following the fourth cycle of the Universal Periodic Review and supported recommendations related to accession to the 1954 and 1961 Statelessness Conventions. These developments could strengthen the national framework for preventing and reducing statelessness and further align legislation and policies with international standards.

AFGHAN RETURNS

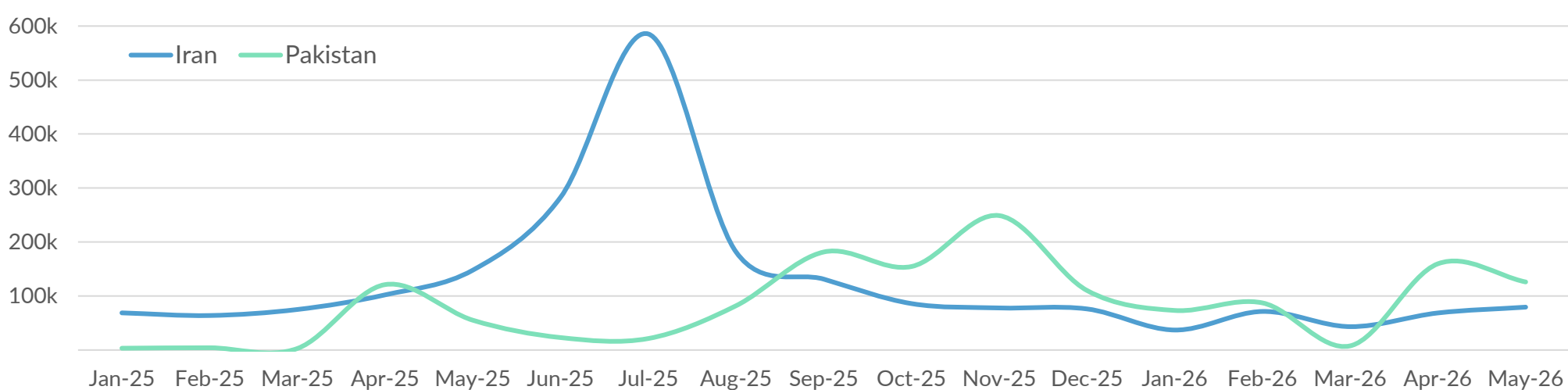
Afghan returns from Iran and Pakistan continued throughout the reporting period, including voluntary and spontaneous movements as well as returns taking place under adverse circumstances. Around 754,100 Afghans had returned from Iran and Pakistan, of whom 39% were deported.

[Returns from Iran](#) accounted for the majority of movements, with around 299,900 people returning, including more than 79% deportations. Ongoing uncertainty, economic hardship and limited livelihood opportunities contributed to sustained return levels, while reports of irregular crossings from Afghanistan into Iran underscored the risks of onward movement and repeated displacement.

[Returns from Pakistan](#) also continued, with 454,200 people returning. Many cited concerns related to documentation status and pressure to leave, while protection monitoring highlighted risks associated with return movements and reintegration.

In **Tajikistan**, returns of Afghans under adverse circumstances increased in May, bringing the cumulative number of deportations since January 2026 to more than 1,000 people, including refugees and asylum-seekers. Reports indicated that some families were removed with limited access to due process, legal assistance or opportunities to appeal. UNHCR continued cross-border efforts to verify cases, support affected families and engage with the authorities to safeguard access to asylum and international protection obligations.

AFGHAN RETURNS FROM IRAN AND PAKISTAN



OPERATIONAL HIGHLIGHTS



UNHCR supported the premiere of *Unfulfilled Duty*, a documentary highlighting Kazakhstan's humanitarian engagement in Afghanistan and support for Afghans affected by displacement, including returnees. Organized by Sayahat Time in partnership with the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Kazakhstan and the Embassy of Kazakhstan in Afghanistan, the screening at UN Plaza in Almaty brought together Government representatives, partners and the diplomatic community.

The event showcased Kazakhstan's longstanding commitment to humanitarian action and regional solidarity with the Afghan people. UNHCR's Representative for Central Asia highlighted the importance of sustained international support for Afghans and acknowledged Kazakhstan's contributions to humanitarian and development efforts across the region.

COORDINATION, COLLABORATION AND CONTINGENCY PLANNING

In **Afghanistan**, UNHCR continued to support inter-agency coordination through border-level mechanisms and the Protection Coordination Group. Efforts focused on strengthening referral pathways, aligning data, identifying service gaps and supporting contingency planning for Afghan returns from Pakistan and Iran. At key reception points, partners worked closely with de facto authorities to address operational challenges affecting reception, processing and onward movement, while improving basic services and assistance delivery. Collaboration also supported the expansion of hot meal distributions, strengthened protection referrals and advanced efforts to harmonise legal assistance and civil documentation services.

In **Iran**, UNHCR continued close engagement with Government counterparts, UN agencies, and partners. Coordination with UNHCR offices in Afghanistan supports cross-border information sharing, monitoring of return movements and alignment of assistance on both sides of the border. Inter-agency mechanisms facilitated joint planning and operational coherence in a fluid and evolving context. Following the expiration of the [Iran Flash Refugee Response Plan](#) at the end of May, partners are preparing an updated Country Refugee Response Plan for June–December 2026 to deliver a more comprehensive response integrating immediate humanitarian needs with broader priorities. The Flash RRP was 24% funded as of 31 May.

In **Pakistan**, UNHCR, together with IOM, UNFPA, UNICEF, and UNDP, conducted an inter-agency mission to the Azakhel Multi-Purpose Hub to support a phased, coordinated service model linked to the Voluntary Repatriation Centre (VRC) and agreed to scale up coordinated protection and assistance services linked to the VRC while ensuring uninterrupted voluntary repatriation. On 25 May, the Refugee Protection Working Group reviewed outcomes of the April Advocacy Sub-Group meeting and endorsed key priorities including stronger engagement, partnerships, outreach, border sensitization and improved protection coordination.

Across **Central Asia**, UNHCR maintained engagement with Government counterparts, including ministries, border and judicial authorities, ombudsperson institutions, and parliamentary and inter-agency bodies, to advance protection and solutions for refugees and stateless persons. Collaboration with UN agencies, development partners, academia and NGOs supported efforts to strengthen asylum systems, promote inclusion in national services and align legislation and policies with international standards.

FUNDING SITUATION

In 2026, UNHCR requires **USD 454.2 million** to support the response to the Afghanistan situation; to date, only **22%** has been received as of 31 May.

UNHCR is grateful to the following donors who have stepped forward with funding, enabling life-saving assistance and protection to reach those most in need:

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